

(3) Protestantism (Protestant Denominations)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Protestantism (all denominations combined) is one of the three major branches of Christianity with more than 700 million members (generally called protestant) worldwide out of approximately 2 billion (2014 estimates) Christians. Protestantism is the main product of the sixteenth century Reformation (also called Protestant Reformation) within Western (Roman Catholic) Christianity, a movement against what it considered to be errors and corruption in the Roman Catholic Church.

~~Officially the Protestant Reformation was initiated by German Roman Catholic monk Martin Luther , when he in his quest to reform the Roman Catholic Church posted his 95 propositions (or theses) against the errors and corruption of the Roman Catholic Church on the Castle Church door at Wittenberg, Germany in 1517 CE.

~~The term 'Protestant' owes its origin to the letter of the German princes who protested against the decision of the "Diet of Speyer"(an Imperial assembly of the Holy Roman Empire) in 1529 which condemned the teachings of Martin Luther as heretical . Since then 'Protestant' refers to an adherent of any of those Christian denomination that separated from the Roman Catholic Church during the Protestant Reformation, or of any group or sub-group descended from them.

~~There is no central authority in Protestantism like the Church of Rome headed by a single pope with supreme power. Instead Protestants consider Bible (Word of God) to be the supreme central authority. Protestantism encourages individual (guided by holy spirit) private interpretation of the Bible. The lack of central authority along with individual interpretation of the Bible resulted differing interpretations or applications of the teachings of the Bible (such as grace, predestination, sacraments etc.) which is the principal cause of so many Protestant denominations in existence today.

~~Protestants also reject the idea of visible 'one holy catholic apostolic church' and apostolic succession. Every denomination within Protestantism considers itself to be part of the 'Invisible Church', the true church of Christ adhering to the teachings of Bible. Some Protestant denominations (like Lutheran, Baptist, Methodist) have churches and members worldwide, and some are confined to a single region, country, or community.

~~The main characteristics of Protestantism are acceptance of Bible (word of God) as the sole authority in all matters of faith and morals, doctrine of salvation by grace through faith alone and belief in the universal priesthood of all believers.

~~Protestantism shares many common beliefs and practices with Roman Catholic Church (and Eastern Orthodox Church) being part of it until the 16th-century Protestant Reformation. They share a common history of first 1500 years of Christianity together.

~In our following discussion we will focus only on generally accepted aspects of Protestantism and where there are differences with Roman Catholic Church. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Catholic (Roman) Church' in our website before proceeding any further. The unique aspects among different protestant denominations will be highlighted under the individual denomination discussion.

PURPOSE OF LIFE

The purpose of life is to know, love and glorify God and live in a joyful and loving relationship with God and others through Jesus.

CONCEPT OF GOD

There is no major difference between Protestantism and Roman Catholicism regarding concept of God.

THE ORTHODOX CREEDS (PROFESSIONS OF THE FAITH)

Like Roman Catholicism the two most important creeds used widely in Protestantism are 'Nicene Creed' and 'Apostle's Creed'. Nicene Creed is almost universally accepted across all protestant denominations.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Unlike Roman Catholicism, Protestantism only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

The Holy Bible: The Holy Bible of Protestantism is composed of a total of 66 books, 7 books less than the Roman Catholic Bible (and 10 books less than Eastern Orthodox Bible). There are 39 books in Old Testament (7 less than Roman Catholic) and 27 books (like other Christian branches) in the New Testament.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the common features of Protestantism among all denominations are discussed in this section)

THE 'FIVE SOLAS'

The 'Five Solas' are the five Latin phrases (or slogans) that emerged since the Protestant Reformation featuring the primary beliefs of Protestantism and differences from Roman Catholicism. These are Sola scriptura (Scripture alone), Sola fide(faith alone), Sola gratia (grace alone), Solo Christo (Christ alone), Soli Deo gloria (glory to God alone). Almost all Protestant denominations accept these ' Five Solas'.

Scripture alone (Sola Scriptura): Sola (only or alone) Scriptura, or scripture alone means, the Bible is the ultimate authority of Christianity. This is also called the 'formal principle' of Protestant Reformation. Bible is the divinely inspired Word of God and is the sole source of all religious information. This confirms the protestant position of rejecting all other worldly authority be it an institution (church of Rome) or an individual (Pope) or traditions (sacred tradition). Simply put all information regarding religious belief, moral and practice must be from the Bible and/or conform to the Bible and/or according to (for) the Bible.

Faith alone (Sola fide): Sola fide, or faith alone means, salvation (and justification) is through faith alone in Jesus Christ. Protestants believe one is saved and justified (being declared just by God) only through faith in Jesus Christ (as Lord and Savior), without any requirement of good works (such as sacraments, charity, indulgences, prayers, efforts or actions) on the part of the individual. Simply put salvation is through faith (alone) not by works.

Grace alone (Sola gratia): Sola gratia, or grace alone means, salvation (one is saved) by the grace of God alone. Grace of God is a divine free gift a totally unmerited-uneared (not a result of any human action or work) favor from God for those who have faith in Jesus Christ.

Christ alone (Solo Christo): Solo Christo or Christ alone means, Christ alone is the way (mediator, means and savior) to salvation. Christ alone is the mediator between human and God. This principle automatically rejects all other mediators (such as pope, priest, Mary and saint etc.) between man and God. It emphasizes that salvation is made possible for man, only through the sinless life, sacrificial death on cross, and bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ. Simply put Jesus Christ is the only way to salvation.

Glory to God alone (Soli Deo gloria): Soli Deo gloria or glory to God alone that is, God alone is the one who is to receive all the glory. The goal of life is to give glory to God alone. It emphasizes no one (such as angels, Mary mother of Jesus or saints etc.) is to be glorified beside God. God alone is worthy and deserving of all glory.

THE CHURCH

In Protestantism, most important difference with Roman Catholicism, there is no single centralized organization (Church of Roma) headed by a single pope with supreme power . There is no Pope (with supreme power) or equivalent in Protestantism. Protestants generally recognize church to be the invisible body of all believers headed by Jesus Christ.

~~Protestants worship spaces, building or physical structures (i.e. the church), in general are characterized by a plainer decoration usually without images and statues than those of Roman Catholics or Eastern Orthodox Christians.

~~Some Protestant churches are fully independent and local while others are part of a national, regional or worldwide protestant denomination.

~~There is no one form of church governance in use across all protestant denominations. The basic

forms of church governance in use are Episcopal, Presbyterian and Congregational polity.

~**Episcopal polity** is a system of church governance (used by Roman Catholic church) which is hierarchical in structure and a bishop (Greek, episcopos) or 'overseer' is the chief authority. This form of church governance is used by many Lutheran and Methodist churches.

~**Congregational (or Congregationalist) polity** is a system of church governance in which every local church is autonomous and independent. In this form each church operates through democratic processes where each member have equal voice in the governance of the church. Usually members will elect a committee or a group of people to manage the day to day affairs of the church. Some of these churches may join certain convention (like Southern Baptist convention) and some may join other congregations (which share same belief and practices) for mutual strength, support or cooperation. This form of church governance is used by Baptist, Anabaptist, Quakers, some Lutherans and Congregational churches.

~**Presbyterian polity** is a system of church governance which is run by assemblies of elders or presbyters. In this form of governance, authority flows both from the bottom (congregation elects elders) up and from the top (as higher assemblies hold certain authority over individual congregations) down. Local elected presbyters make decisions for the local church in a body called the session or consistory. Group of local churches are governed by higher assembly of presbyters called Presbytery. Group of Presbyteries are governed by a Synod. Synods together compose the final governing authority called General Assembly. This forms of church governance is used by Presbyterian and Reformed churches.

THE CLERGY

In many (not all) Protestant denominations, women are not allowed to be part of the clergy. Unlike Roman Catholics, Protestants do not require celibacy as a condition of election to the clergy.

~~Protestantism also do not consider ordination of the clergy as a sacrament. Clergies are viewed more as individuals with religious knowledge (scholar) and zeal, the representative of the community, appointed (ordained) and chosen to lead its spiritual life.

~~Protestantism also rejects (unlike Roman Catholicism) the idea that clergy such as bishops and priests are successors of the apostles (Apostolic succession), mediators between man and God and have exclusive privileges regarding the dispensation of grace.

~~In Episcopal polity the clergy include deacons, pastors/priests and bishops. In Presbyterian and Congregational Polity the clergy include deacons, ruling elders (elder board) and teaching elders/presbyters may also be known bishop or pastor or reverend or minister.

MONKS AND NUNS

Unlike Roman Catholicism, practice of monasticism (monkhood) is generally not existent within mainstream protestant denominations.

MARY

Mary is considered a holy woman, highly honored and respected as chosen by God to be the mother of Jesus through a virgin birth. But unlike Roman Catholics, Protestants generally reject immaculate conception, assumption, perpetual virginity and intercession of Mary.

THE SAINTS

Unlike Roman Catholicism, Protestantism considers all believers in Jesus as savior, as saints and are called to be saints. Protestantism rejects veneration and intercession of a special group of believers as saints.

THE ANGELS

Main difference with Roman Catholicism is that Protestantism rejects the intercession of angels.

THE FALLEN ANGELS (SATAN AND DEMONS)

There is no major difference between Protestantism and Roman Catholicism regarding belief about fallen angels.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Protestant denominations accept only two sacraments (also known as ordinances) : Baptism and the Eucharist (also known as communion or the Lord's Supper). All other sacraments are only considered as rituals or rites as those do not meet criterion for sacraments. The other important difference is that Protestantism doesn't consider any of the sacraments absolutely necessary for salvation.

~~While some protestants accept a third sacrament (Confession) others (like the Quakers) accept none.

~~There are different views within Protestantism about how the sacraments are defined and understood, which lead to division within Protestantism. As a result among Protestant denominations contemporary practices of baptism and the Lord's Supper vary greatly which will be discussed in the particular denomination section.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, Protestant liturgies are simpler and place greater emphasis on preaching (sermon) and reading from the Bible. The other key difference is Protestants do not participate in any kind of intercessory prayer (like Roman Catholic 'Prayer of intercession') or

celebrate holidays related to Mary, saints or angels.

~~A great emphasis is put on regular Bible study, private prayer and attending church services on Sunday. There are wide variety of worship styles among protestant denominations ranging from the spontaneity of the Pentecostal churches to more traditional worship of the Lutheran churches in some ways similar to the Roman Catholic Church. Singing hymns in choir or in congregational participation during church services are common in many protestant denominations.

SIN

A notable difference with Roman Catholicism is that Protestantism does not categorize sins into mortal and venial sins. Other key difference is Protestants believe that sins (except for blasphemy against Holy Spirit) do not harm their eternal relationship with God, once they have acquired salvation (they are saved for eternity). Though recognizing if or when a Protestant gets involved in sin, he or she may suffer worldly, physical, mental or spiritual consequences.

Forgiveness of Sin: Protestants believe that Jesus Christ upon his death on cross paid for all sins ever committed and will be committed for all those who believe in him. So when one commits sin, he or she may confess to God through Jesus and ask for forgiveness which will restore the perfect fellowship and communion with God.

SALVATION

A major difference with Roman Catholics is that Protestants believe Salvation is through faith alone in Jesus. Salvation is by grace (free unmerited-undeserved gift from God) through faith in Jesus Christ. Protestants believe (unlike Roman Catholics) good works is not necessary for salvation. Protestants recognize the importance of good works but believe good works is the fruit of their salvation (a consequence of receiving salvation) and not part of the process to be saved.

~~Unlike Roman Catholics, most Protestants do not believe salvation can be lost due to sin (except for blasphemy against Holy Spirit).

ESCHATOLOGY

The main difference here is that unlike Roman Catholics, Protestants do not accept the concept of Purgatory. After death till resurrection(this temporary-intermediate state) the souls of the believers end up in heavenly bliss and others in eternal damnation. There is no changing of state of salvation or cleansing with fire (like roman Catholicism) after death in the intermediate period, one is either saved or damned for eternity.

INDULGENCE

Unlike Roman Catholicism, Protestantism rejects the concept of 'indulgence' .

STATUES AND IMAGES

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Protestant denominations abstain from excessive usage of statues and images in the religious sphere of life since God forbade the worship of statues, images and icons. For this very reason Protestant Churches are usually devoid of statues and images.

SEXUAL MORALITY

There is no major difference between Protestants and Roman Catholics regarding the teachings about sexual morality. The only difference is that Protestants do not consider sexual immorality such as masturbation, fornication, pornography, prostitution, rape, adultery etc. (though considered as sins) can cause loss of salvation.

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

Unlike Roman Catholicism there is no universal position on matter of contraception within the Protestantism. Up until twentieth century Protestantism position was similar to Roman Catholicism, where contraception was condemned as a violation of God's procreative purpose of marriage. But since then a lesser strict view coming to prevail, where most Protestant denominations usually allow use of some sort of contraception within marriage as a responsible way of family planning.

ABORTION

Like Roman Catholicism, Protestantism generally considers it to be immoral to have or to associate with abortion. But unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Protestant denominations consider abortion as a legal option in the case of rape, incest or 'life of mother'. There is no universal position among Protestant denominations on abortion. Views ranges from totally against abortion (identical to Catholicism) to mothers life and choice being an important consideration.

MARRIAGE, DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Protestant denominations do not consider marriage as unbreakable union or a sacrament though they consider it to be sacred, holy and permanent union. Unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Protestant denominations also allow divorce and remarriage under certain circumstances. Views ranges from divorce allowed only in the case of adultery to mutual incompatibility and dislike.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

https://gotquestions.org/search.php?zoom_query=protestant&search.x=0&search.y=0,
<http://protestantism.co.uk/>,
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